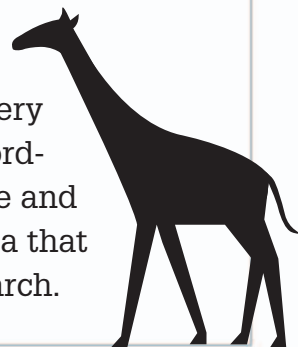


ZOOKEEPER

JOB DESCRIPTION

A zookeeper looks after wild, rare, and exotic animals in zoos, animal parks, or aquariums. In this active, often outdoor job, duties range from feeding, washing, and grooming animals to designing and maintaining enclosures, assisting with the delivery of medical care to animals, and record-keeping. Zookeepers may also guide and educate zoo visitors, and collect data that may be useful in conservation research.



SALARY

Zookeeper ★★★★★

Head keeper ★★☆☆☆

INDUSTRY PROFILE

Strong competition for entry-level positions • More applicants than vacancies • Higher salaries offered in larger zoos

CAREER PATHS

Experience working with animals is required in order to become a zookeeper. Prospective zookeepers can pick up useful skills by joining volunteer programs, offered by most zoos and animal parks, or through voluntary or paid work in a pet store, stable, or farm. Senior roles are rare, so progression usually requires moving to another zoo.

VOLUNTEER Although you will not always have direct contact with animals as a volunteer, you can still gain valuable experience of working in a zoo environment. These opportunities are very popular, so you may have to join a waiting list.

APPRENTICE You can gain useful experience by taking a related college course or applying for an apprenticeship, both of which may involve direct contact with animals.



GRADUATE You will need a degree in zoology, biology, or a related field in order to progress to a senior or more specialized position in this profession.



ZOOKEEPER Once you have gained experience you may be able to join—or apply for promotion at—a larger zoo, where there may be good prospects for progression. Opportunities also exist in education and conservation research.